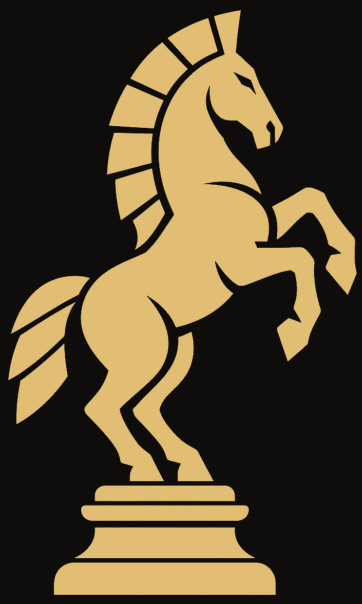


10 OPENING TRAPS CHEAT SHEET

The ten traps every beginner meets. For each one: what happens in plain words, the exact moment it goes wrong, and how not to fall for it.

THROIY CHESS · @THROIYCHESS



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e4 e5 Bc4 Nc6 Qh5 Nf6 Qxf7#

TRAP 01

Scholar's Mate

KING'S PAWN OPENING · WHITE SETS IT

Queen and bishop gang up on f7. Mate in four moves, unless you defend first.

White points the queen and a bishop at one weak square next to Black's king. If Black doesn't defend it, the queen takes it and it's checkmate in four moves. Block the queen first, then chase it away.

> **THE BLUNDER 3...Nf6??** The knight attacks the queen. Natural, but it ignores f7.

HOW NOT TO FALL FOR IT

- After Qh5, defend first: block with g6 or protect f7 with Qe7.
- Once f7 is safe, develop your knights and make the white queen run.
- An early queen is a target, not a danger, as long as you defend first.



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e4 e5 Nf3 d6 Bc4 Bg4 Nc3 g6 Nxe5 Bxd1 Bxf7+ Ke7 Nd5#

TRAP 02

Légal's Mate

PHILIDOR DEFENSE · WHITE SETS IT

White gives away the queen and mates in two. Almost 300 years old, and it still works.

White seems to give away the queen for free. If Black grabs it, three small pieces trap the black king and it's checkmate two moves later. Don't take the queen: take the knight instead. You lose a pawn, not the game.

> **THE BLUNDER 5...Bxd1??** Black grabs the queen. Now White's small pieces strike.

HOW NOT TO FALL FOR IT

- Don't grab the queen. Take the knight with 5...dxe5 instead.
- You lose a pawn, not the game. A free queen is never free when your king is in danger.



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e4 e5 Nf3 Nc6 Bc4 Nf6 Ng5 d5 exd5 Nxd5 Nxf7 Kxf7 Qf3+ Ke6 Nc3

TRAP 03

Fried Liver Attack

ITALIAN GAME · WHITE SETS IT

White gives up a knight on f7 and drags Black's king into the middle of the board.

White sacrifices a knight to pull Black's king out of its safe spot. The king ends up in the middle of the board, where every white piece can attack it. Avoid it: don't take back in the center, attack the bishop with your knight instead.

> **THE MISTAKE 5...Nxd5?** Taking back with the knight looks natural. It's the mistake.

HOW NOT TO FALL FOR IT

- Don't take back on d5 with the knight. Play 5...Na5! and attack the bishop.
- A king in the center is a target. Keep it behind its pawns.



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e4 e5 Nf3 Nc6 Bb5 Nf6 O-O Ng4 h3 h5 hxg4 hxg4 Nh2 Qh4 f3 g3 Rf2 Nd4 Kf1 gxh2 Ke1 h1=Q+ Bf1 Qxf1+ Kxf1 Qh1#

TRAP 04

Fishing Pole Trap

RUY LOPEZ · BLACK SETS IT

Black leaves a knight hanging on g4. Take it, and the h-file opens straight onto your king.

Black leaves a knight hanging right next to White's king. If White takes it, a whole column opens up towards the king, and Black's queen and rook give checkmate in the corner. Kicking the knight away is fine. Taking it is not.

> **THE BLUNDER 6.hxg4??** A free knight? Taking it is the real blunder.

HOW NOT TO FALL FOR IT

- Don't push the h-pawn when the knight lands on g4. h3 is the first mistake.
- Your king hides behind f2, g2 and h2. Keep them home and keep developing.
- If the knight is left hanging after ...h5, don't take it. The open h-file is worth more than a knight.
- As Black it is a cheeky blitz trick. It only works if they bite, so don't count on it.



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e4 e5 Nf3 Nc6 Bc4 Nd4 Nxe5 Qg5 Nxf7 Qxg2 Rf1 Qxe4+ Be2 Nf3#

TRAP 05

Blackburne Shilling Gambit

ITALIAN GAME · BLACK SETS IT

Black hangs a pawn on purpose. Grab it, get greedy, and it's mate on move seven.

Black leaves a pawn hanging on purpose. If White grabs it and then goes for even more, Black's queen crashes in and a knight gives checkmate. Don't take the pawn: castle, or take Black's knight.

> **THE BLUNDER 5.Nxf7??** White goes for more: queen and rook are both attacked. Too slow.

HOW NOT TO FALL FOR IT

- Don't take on e5. Castle, or take the knight on d4.
- If you did take and the queen comes to g5, don't grab more: defend g2.
- A free pawn that opens lines to your king is not free.



▶ **Step through it on throiychess.com**

e4 e5 Nf3 Nf6 Nxe5 Nc6 Nxc6 dxc6 d3 Bc5 Bg5 Nxe4 Bxd8 Bxf2+ Ke2 Bg4#

TRAP 06

Stafford Gambit

PETROV DEFENSE · BLACK SETS IT

Black gives away the queen on purpose. Take it, and it's mate in two.

Black gives away the queen on purpose. If White takes it, Black's bishops and knight checkmate White's king two moves later. Before you grab a queen, check every check your opponent has.

> **THE BLUNDER 7.Bxd8??** White takes the queen.

HOW NOT TO FALL FOR IT

- Don't play Bg5. Develop with Be2 and castle.
- Before you grab a queen, check every check.
- f2 is weak in the opening. Watch out for bishops aiming at it.



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d4 e5 dxe5 Nc6 Nf3 Qe7 Bf4 Qb4+ Bd2 Qxb2 Bc3 Bb4 Qd2 Bxc3 Qxc3 Qc1#

TRAP 07

Englund Gambit

ENGLUND GAMBIT · BLACK SETS IT

Black gives a pawn on move one. Chase the queen the wrong way and it's mate on your back rank.

Black throws away a pawn on move one and brings the queen out early. If White chases the queen the wrong way, the row behind White's king is left empty, and the queen gives checkmate there. Develop your knight instead and keep that row covered.

THE BLUNDER 6.Bc3?? White attacks the queen, but leaves c1 unguarded.

HOW NOT TO FALL FOR IT

- After the queen takes b2, play Nc3, not Bc3.
- Keep your back rank covered when the enemy queen is close to it.



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d4 d5 c4 e6 Nc3 Nf6 Bg5 Nbd7 cxd5 exd5 Nxd5 Nxd5 Bxd8 Bb4+ Qd2 Bxd2+ Kxd2 Kxd8

TRAP 08

Elephant Trap

QUEEN'S GAMBIT DECLINED · BLACK SETS IT

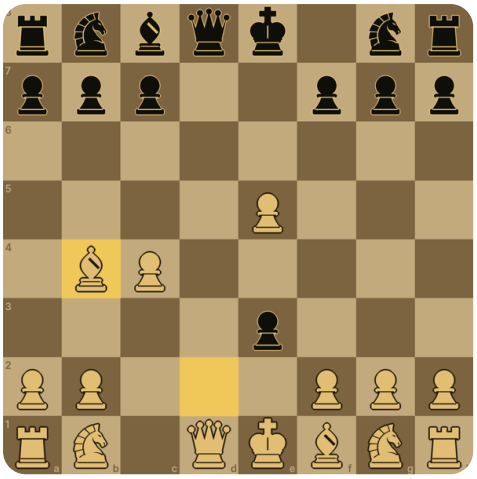
The d5 pawn looks free. Grab it and you lose a whole piece.

A pawn looks free because the knight defending it seems stuck. It isn't. If White grabs the pawn, Black gives the queen, wins it straight back with check and ends up a whole piece ahead. Count the pieces before you grab.

THE GREED 6.Nxd5?? White grabs the pawn, trusting the pin.

HOW NOT TO FALL FOR IT

- A pinned knight can still move if it wins something bigger. Check that first.
- Don't take on d5 here. Just develop with e3.



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d4 d5 c4 e5 dxe5 d4 e3 Bb4+ Bd2 dxe3 Bxb4 exf2+ Ke2 fxg1=N+

TRAP 09

Lasker Trap

ALBIN COUNTER-GAMBIT · BLACK SETS IT

A pawn marches all the way and turns into a knight, with check.

Black pushes a pawn deep into White's position. If White grabs a bishop, that pawn keeps capturing, reaches the last row and turns into a knight with check. White's position falls apart. Bring your knight out early instead.

> **THE BLUNDER 6.Bxb4??** White grabs the bishop.

HOW NOT TO FALL FOR IT

- Play 4.Nf3 instead of e3.
- When an enemy pawn is that close to your king, deal with the pawn before you grab anything.



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e4 c5 d4 cxd4 c3 dxc3 Nxc3 Nc6 Nf3 e6 Bc4 Qc7 O-O Nf6 Qe2 Ng4 h3 Nd4 Nxd4 Qh2#

TRAP 10

Siberian Trap

SMITH-MORRA GAMBIT · BLACK SETS IT

Queen and knight aim at h2. Kick the knight and it's mate in two.

Black's queen and knight both aim at the square next to White's king. If White kicks the knight and then takes the bait, the only defender of that square disappears and the queen gives checkmate. Don't kick the knight: chase the queen away instead.

> **THE BLUNDER 9.h3??** White kicks the knight. It looks natural.

HOW NOT TO FALL FOR IT

- Don't play h3. Play Nb5 and chase the queen away from h2.
- When two pieces aim at the square next to your king, keep its defender in place.

Want to see them move?

All ten traps in one video, step by step, with the fix for each one.

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